farmhouse. However, Léa noticed Édouard's watchfulness, stopping to listen if a car approached, as if he was always on guard.

"Time for lunch," Virginie called out, coming up the hill carrying a basket and blanket. Paulette jumped and waved the pocket-sized spiral sketchbook in front of Rose. Édouard said that André had bought it, intending to give it to Rose as a surprise. "He traded it for a bottle of wine from my reserves," he explained after both sisters stared at him with wide eyes, knowing the cost of paper.

Rose carried it always, sketching some part of the vineyard every day at lunch: the oak tree, vegetables growing at the back, the rows of trellised vines, the stone farmhouse, lavender bushes, the nuts that had tumbled from the walnut tree, stray cats stalking mice through the tall grass, robins and blue tits and the occasional kite swooping in and, of course, the LeBlanc family. Paulette, mesmerized, would sit beside Rose, shifting her gaze from the object to the sketchbook, trying to decipher how she did it.

Today, Virginie had picked pears from the orchard surrounding the vines. They were ripe and glowed yellow-green with russet rims. Even before Rose finished eating, she arranged the pears and walnuts, opening some and placing the broken shells around the fruit. She added a ceramic pitcher, placing it to the right of the pears. Then she began to sketch. Paulette knelt down by her side, peering over Rose's shoulder.

Léa thought of the pastels taken by Madame Martin, and how perfect the green, yellow and red pigments would be for what she was drawing now. Since their arrival in Combleux, neither sister had spoken of that night. But the unfairness stung.

"*Voilà*," Rose said. "A still life with walnuts, pears and a pitcher."

"What's a still life?" Paulette asked.

"A still life—"

The rumble of a diesel engine drowned out Rose's voice. The women looked at one another. Only German officers drove vehicles. Sensing the mood had shifted, Paulette yanked on her mother's sleeve. "What's wrong, Maman?"

Virginie stood. "I'll take Paulette and Rose to the vege-table garden in the back." She held her arms out as if to gather them up. "Léa, please go and see if Édouard needs help."

An unspoken agreement existed between Virginie and Léa—both felt a